turned to Murugan next and said, ‘Yours too.’ While Murugan, too, remained silent, Nalini looked at Verma again. Murugan then spoke softly, ‘I was sleeping in my house and never went out.’ Verma knew he was lying, but he was happy that Murugan had said something.

His answer, whether true or false, underlined Nalini’s refusal to answer. Her lack of a vehement reply was an indirect admission that she was at the venue.

Verma then told the duo about witnesses who had confirmed their presence at the venue and their links with the human bomb. Kanth produced ‘confessional statements’ of those witnesses, where they had implicated Nalini and Murugan as co-conspirators in the assassination. The documents were fake, but, of course, neither of them knew that.

Raju and Kanth took over the interrogation. Kanth, who had rich experience in cracking Punjab terrorists during the Khalistan movement, tried every technique he had. So did Raju, who was known for compelling Kashmiri militants to talk during interrogation. Yet, there was no success with Nalini and Murugan. The couple just wouldn’t admit they had anything to do with Rajiv Gandhi’s assassination. Finally Raju confronted Nalini with the photograph taken at Sriperumbudur, hoping it would jolt her. It did not. Nalini told Raju her presence at Sriperumbudur was no proof of her being an assassin. She refused to identify the girl accompanying her (Subha) in the women’s enclosure in the photograph.

Captain Ravindran had been watching the interrogation, which had led nowhere even after two days. He could not take it any more. The nature of his work required split-second decisions and split-second action. After convincing Raju to give him a chance to crack the duo, Ravindran entered the room where only Nalini was sitting and asked the two armed female constables to leave. He would handle her alone. Ravindran removed his belt and threatened her with something she would regret till the time she was hanged for murdering Rajiv Gandhi. Nalini didn’t succumb to his threats. She shot back, saying IPKF soldiers had ‘raped women in Jaffna’. She asked Ravindran if he was only following in the footsteps of the IPKF. Ravindran couldn’t care less. He removed the first button of his jeans.